Anthropogenic biomes

The biosphere—all the areas of Earth and its atmosphere that contain living things—consists of biomes, which are large ecosystems based on a specific environment, such as desert or tropical rainforest. The impact of human actions on biodiversity and the consequent reshaping of much of the planet have led ecologists to reassess biomes and suggest that a designation of anthropogenic (human-made) biomes is now necessary. Anthropogenic biomes are grouped into six main categories: dense settlements; villages; croplands; rangeland; forested; and wildlands.

Unlike other biomes, which can range across continents, anthropogenic biomes are a mosaic of pockets over Earth's surface. According to ecologists, more than 75 percent of Earth's ice-free land has been affected by at least some form of human activity, particularly in dense settlements (urban areas), which account for over half the world's population, and villages (dense agricultural settlements).

See also: Biodiversity hotspots • Animal ecology • Biodiversity and ecosystem function • Biomes • Mass extinctions • Deforestation • Overfishing • Halting biodiversity loss